Music in Western Civilization

Session 26

Topic 10

Traditonal Songs from USA, the British Isles, France and Germany in the 19th - early 20th century

Professor Chan Wing Wah
陈永华教授

2026

Negro spirituals 黑人灵歌

Spiritual music, or African-American spirituals

- From 16th through 19th century, approximately 12 million Africans were shipped to US. About 1.5 million died on board ship. *Patrick Manning*. They mainly worked in cotton fields and farms;
- In 1860, 4 million black people of the 32 million Americans (~13%) were slaves mostly in the South;
- These slaves created songs on their miserable enslaved life at times with Christian elements;
- Many of these songs were arranged into group singing and chorus singing, a lot of the time unaccompanied (a cappella);
- 1861-65 US Civil War with the Union North against the Confederacy South ended slavery trade.

Slave Songs of the United States was a collection of African American music consisting of 136 songs, published in 1867

- *Michael Rows the Boat Ashore*
- (#31) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=P-MSCXTqZXI

- *Bosom of Abraham* (#94 as "Rock My Soul")
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tAl8wviLWTk

- *Nobody Knows the Trouble I've Seen*
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Q3_r60kk2Ko Louis Armstrong, jazz version

Gospel Songs

- *We Shall Overcome* (Gospel Song, 1901)
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Aor6-DkzBJ0
- Morehouse College Glee Club

- "Oh Happy Day" Edwin Hawkins - Anthony Brown w/ FBCG Combined Choir
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=olQrCfkvbGw

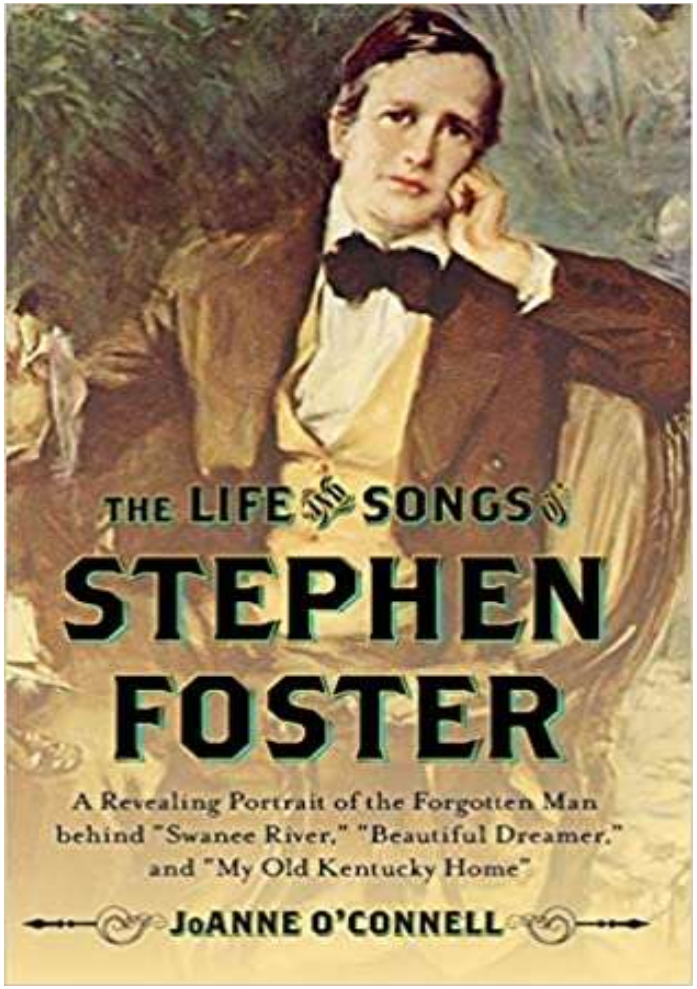
Stephen Foster 1826-1864

American songwriter with African American as subject in some of his over 200 songs

- *Old Black Joe*
  https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TzHSp0UqoJ8

- *Old Susanna*
  https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WFab0GEbp8Y

- *Swanee River*
  https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fB3qn1MNWNY



My Old Kentucky Home https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=849jXwFTX5Y

The sun shines bright in the old Kentucky home.
'Tis summer, the darkies are gay,
The corn top's ripe and the meadow's in the bloom
While the birds make music all the day.
The young folks roll on the little cabin floor,
All merry, all happy, and bright.
By 'n by hard times comes a-knocking at the door,
Then my old Kentucky home, good night.

Weep no more my lady, oh! weep no more today!
We will sing one song for the old Kentucky home,
For the old Kentucky home far away.
The head must bow and the back will have to bend,
Wherever the darkies may go.
A few more days and the trouble all will end,
In the field where the sugar-canes grow.
A few more days for to tote the weary load,
No matter 'twill never be light.
A few more days till we totter on the road,
Then my old Kentucky home, good-night!

From the British Isles

- England (London)
- Scotland (Edinburgh)
- Wales (Cardiff)

- Ireland
- (Now the independent *Republic of Ireland* which became a Free State in 1937 and **a Republic in 1949**, capital Dublin;
- and the UK *Northern Ireland* capital city Belfast)


United Kingdom UK
Orkney Islands
Shetland Islands
Hebrides
Inverness
SCOTLAND
Aberdeen
Island of Skye
Fort William
North Sea
Edinburgh
Atlantic Ocean
Glasgow
Belfast
Carlisle
York
NORTHERN IRELAND
Isle of Man
Liverpool
Irish Sea
Manchester
Dublin
ENGLAND
Birmingham
Ireland
Cambridge
Bristol
WALES
Oxford
Celtic Sea
Cardiff
London
Bath
Brighton
Exeter
Isle of Wight
Dover
100 mi
100 km
Plymouth
English Channel
France

English Traditional Songs

- *God Rest Ye Merry Gentlemen*, 16th century
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FlfHyb397VY

- *Scarborough Fair*, 17th century
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-BakWVXHSug Simon and Garfunkel

Folksong style

- *Down by the Sally Garden* (**Irish** traditional song)
  https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=027ZJX5XVjs folk song style
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=awGJKkY55s4 arr. John Rutter for Male Chorus
- Lyrics: William Butler Yeats; Music: Herbert Hughes 1909

- Down by the salley gardens, my love and I did meet;
  She passed the salley gardens with little snow-white feet.
  She bid me take love easy as the leaves grow on the tree;
  But I, being young and foolish, with her would not agree.

- In a field by the river, my love and I did stand,
  And on my leaning shoulder, she laid her snow-white hand.
- She bid me take life easy, as the grass grows on the weirs;
  But I was young and foolish, and now am full of tears.

Traditional **Irish** Melody

Londonderry Air/O Danny Boy

published in 1855

Choir of Jesus College, Cambridge

(the College was established in 1496)

- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jmp6VcUIFMg

- National Taiwan University Chorus
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=s7oy8vBCGfs

- The King's Singers
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SfGTq71VXfo

Irish song pub. 1813 *The Last Rose of Summer*

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jzZ5jPURUVo Celtic Woman (est. 2004)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hB_x5evLWjg putonghua

- 'Tis the last rose of summer, Left blooming alone;
  All her lovely companions Are faded and gone;
  No flower of her kindred, No rose-bud is nigh,
  To reflect back her blushes Or give sigh for sigh!

  I'll not leave thee, thou lone one. To pine on the stem;
  Since the lovely are sleeping, Go, sleep thou with them;
  Thus kindly I scatter Thy leaves o'er the bed,
  Where thy mates of the garden Lie scentless and dead.

  So soon may *I* follow, When friendships decay,
  And from love's shining circle The gems drop away!
  When true hearts lie withered, And fond ones are flown,
  Oh! who would inhabit This bleak world alone?[4]

Sea Shanties and Boatman Songs

- ***Irish**: What Shall We Do with the Drunken Sailors*
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=qGyPuey-1Jw

- **Scottish** : *Skye Boat Song*
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=n1CTxa-FuKc

- **Scottish** Traditional Song : *Loch Lomond*
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=feLT7Btuqpc
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=S0086LpnGxk The Ramparts Chamber Choir, Dublin

Scottish song: *O Waly Waly*, pub. 1906

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4bXSGLpIHu0 arr.: John Rutter

- The water is wide, I cannot cross o'er,
  And neither have I the wings to fly.
  Build me a boat that can carry two
  And both shall row, my true love and I.

  A ship there is and she sails the sea
  She's laden deep, as deep can be.
  But not so deep as the love I'm in,
  And I know not if I sink or swim.

  I leaned my back against a young oak,
  Thinking 'twere a trusty tree.
  But first it bent and then it broke,
  Thus did my love prove false to me

Welsh Folksong

- Sosban Fach
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cilThfDX66A

- The London Welsh Festival of Male Choirs 2014
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Hf7OLQGHJT0

Scottish: *Auld Lang Syne* (The Old Days)

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=W_6Vs8pADrQ Choral Scholars of University College Dublin
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gxxpyhrmoZg Last Night of the Proms 2009

- Words: Robert Burns, 1788; Melody: 1799

- Should auld acquaintance be forgot,
  and never brought to mind?
  Should auld acquaintance be forgot,
  the days of auld lang syne?[a]
  Chorus:

  For auld lang syne, my dear,
  for auld lang syne,
  we'll tak' a cup o' kindness yet,
  for auld lang syne.

German folksongs

- *Muss ich denn*
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FOLtePm8B6w&list=RDFOLtePm8B6w&start_radio=1
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=89JO19UV7DI

- *O Tannenbaum* (Pine Tree=Christmas Tree)
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZLqbkBPNEUU&list=RDZLqbkBPNEUU&start_radio=1

French Folksong

- *Frère Jacques* (17th century)
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XrPiWFxmY24
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PW5_f6GnSLo Barbershop style

- *Ah vous dirai-je, maman* (c.1740)
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VlNThOqPmqo